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word choices that may be interpreted as biased, discriminatory or demeaning by implying that the prevailing social gender—gender-specific behaviour and attitudes considered appropriate—is the norm. It believes that using gender-fair and inclusive language helps reduce gender stereotyping, promotes social change and contributes to achieving gender equality.

The navy accepts that language is a powerful medium that directly influences the perceptions and behaviours of individuals and organisations. Embracing gender-neutral language is more than just a matter of political correctness; it is essential towards ensuring that no gender is privileged, and prejudices against any gender are not perpetuated. Naval HQ maintains that imbuing gender-neutrality in correspondence would act as a crucial enabler of inclusivity in the navy—firstly, to challenge subconscious bias against stereotypical gender roles; secondly, to lay the foundation for greater gender equality and thirdly, to develop cognisance of how language affects behaviours and attitudes.

As per the communiqué issued by Rear Admiral Rahul Vilas Gokhale, the navy believes that the advancement of gender equality by migrating to a gender-neutral language does not require significant resources or investment. However, it is definitely a starting point towards creating a work culture of inclusivity that fosters greater participation and cohesiveness in the service. "Conscious efforts by all personnel would go a long way in promoting gender-neutral language," Rear Admiral Gokhle stated in his communiqué.

THE NAVY SAYS GENDER-NEUTRAL LANGUAGE IS ESSENTIAL TOWARDS ENSURING THAT NO GENDER IS PRIVILEGED

The Navy has also advised the use of passive or imperative statements like 'incoming formalities are to be completed by all officers within two weeks' in lieu of earlier ones like 'every officer must complete his incoming formalities within two weeks'. However, age-old words like 'master' and 'mate' are deemed to be of neutral usage that do not always connote the male gender. Accordingly, 'quartermaster' and 'boatswain's mate' are assessed as gender-neutral terms too. The navy has decided to replace terms like 'manpower' with 'workforce' or 'human capital', 'chairman' with 'chairperson' or the 'chair', 'manning plan' with 'staffing plan' and 'serviceman' with 'service person'. ■

MIXED BAG

By Rahul Noronha

Project Cheetah, dubbed as the first intercontinental translocation of a large wild carnivore, completes one year on September 17. It was on this day in 2022 that Prime Minister Narendra Modi released eight African cheetahs flown in from Namibia into enclosures at Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh—marking the culmination of decades-long efforts that saw much deliberation and judicial interventions. The past one year, however, has only triggered further debate over whether the ambitious project is a success or a failure.

Reason: the cheetah fatalities. Of the 20 big cats translocated so far—12 were brought from South Africa in February—six died between March 27 and August 2. The cause of death ranges from renal or cardio-pulmonary failure to neck injuries (due to radio collars) resulting in septicemia. On August 13, all 14 surviving cheetahs were captured and brought back to the enclosures, pending release after the monsoon.

Per S.P. Yadav, member secretary, National Tiger Conservation Authority, the Cheetah Action Plan, prepared before the big cats were released at Kuno, set six benchmarks for the project's short-term success. "Four have been met," he says. For instance, one of the benchmarks was the survival of at least 50 per cent of the cheetahs in the first year. Going by that, the project can be termed a success, as six, or 75 per cent, of the eight Namibian cheetahs have survived. (Among those brought from South Africa, the survival rate is 67 per cent as of now.)

By far, the biggest success is the will shown by African cheetahs to adapt to their new home, hunting animals like sambar and cheetal that they had not even seen before. The cheetahs also successfully bred on the Indian soil, as a litter of four cubs was delivered in March even if only one survived. "Community